

the Indian Muslim is not in bad company. The so-called "fascist majority" is an invention of professional conscience-keepers from the Left-liberal establishment. Angry gods and misread scriptures have failed to divide India.

Is it then the secular ideal that keeps us one? The triumph of the Nehruvian New Man over the false deities of religion? Officially enforced secularism, like any other ism, challenges the essential wisdom of India, which has historically accepted the polyphony of cultures and religions. Today, the generals of Turkey, keepers of Kemal Ataturk's legacy of iron-fist secularism, are realising how the tyranny of secularism could set the stage for Islamist revival. It is not all that secular when you declare war on headscarves. It is not wiser to deny religion its freedom in a secular country like India too. Politics has, anyway, not succeeded in taking ownership of Hinduism, the religion of the majority. Its elasticity, its refusal to be straitjacketed by the lunatic fringe of the right, has ensured that an Indian citizen doesn't have to be an outsider because of his religion. Elsewhere in the world, the Enemy is being manufactured from the raw material of fear and the paranoia of those who control the streets. In India, the Enemy may have acquired residency

in slogans of desperation—not in the national mind though. A new generation in India is not trapped in the so-called hyphenated history of the subcontinent.

We, as a nation, are not in permanent pursuit of definition: who are we? The question can turn divisive, bloody. In search of a self-serving, exclusivist definition, the culturally insecure may travel back to the remote provinces of the past. They get intoxicated by the perfumed glory of the great yesterday. They get vengeful as they reach the sites of vandalised civilisations. India has its share of historical hurt. And it cannot be denied by any amount of modernist malarkey. A nation

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without a sense of history is an empty place, and it is as bad as a nation weighed down by the nationalist mythology. Still, we have not let those who picnic in the past to take complete copyright of the national conscience. The Indian unity is a repudiation of their extremities.

It doesn't mean that we are lost in the magic of here and now, that we are unified by the rewards of the marketplace and the make-believe of the multiplexes alone, though it may be true that a Tamil film like *Sivaji*, a cartoon spectacle without subtitles, can keep Delhi transfixed for three hours. In a movie hall or on the cricket ground, India will continue to be transported to the ideal of nationalist intimacy. What really makes Indian unity exceptionally exciting is its volatility. It is never monotonous. It defies the tyranny of homogeneity. The world's noisiest democracy is a celebration of differences, which are accentuated by every shade of salvation, ranging from sub-rural socialism to the neo-Soviet variety. And it has survived the worst instincts of its political class. When arguments divide nations, India is united by their variety—like the following pages. ■

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